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Report Author(s): Daniel Sobelman

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Chapter 1

Historical Background of Hizbollah, “The Party of God”

Approximately one month after the September 11 al-Qaeda terrorist attacks in Washington and New York, United States president George W. Bush published a list of the twenty-two people most wanted by the American government for terror activity against American targets. Evident immediately was that the United States was far from accepting the statute of limitations in deadly attacks that claimed the lives of hundreds of American soldiers and civilians in Beirut in the early 1980s. Heading the list was Osama Bin Laden, the founder and leader of the al-Qaeda organization, but also appearing were the names of three Lebanese: Imad Mughniyah, Hasan Izz al-Din, and Ali Atwa. According to published FBI files, the three were officially accused of hijacking a TWA passenger plane on June 14, 1985, which resulted in an attack on passengers and crew and the murder of one American citizen.

Mughniyah, identified as the leader of the Islamic Jihad¹ – the group responsible for Hizbollah activity outside of Lebanon – first surfaced in the 1980s in connection with showcase attacks against the American embassy and the multinational forces building in Beirut in 1983, in which 241 American marines and fifty-eight French soldiers were killed, and in connection with his central involvement in the kidnappings of American and other Western citizens in Lebanon.² When his name appeared in 2001, the heads of Hizbollah had the impression that the American administration was opening an “old file” – as the affair was termed in the Lebanese media. Various analyses of American intentions were published in the Beirut press.

Already in November 1994 Hizbollah Secretary-General Hassan Nasrallah publicly condemned the plans of Lebanese legal authorities to reopen an investigation and pursue those responsible for the blast that leveled the multinational forces building more than a decade earlier.³ Nasrallah warned of the consequences of such a move, which he termed “ridiculous.” By November 2001, however, he realized the need to issue an official denial of the charge that his organization harbored a foreign security

unit to initiate global Hizbollah activity. In a speech delivered in Beirut at the end of the Ramadan fast, Nasrallah stated that the accusation of Hizbollah involvement in international terror was “scandalous and void of any basis” and that “Hizbollah is a resistance movement founded as a Lebanese response to the Zionist occupation.”⁴ Crucial here is that this reaction reflects Hizbollah’s self-image and self-presentation as an organization that has evolved a great deal since the people identified with and linked to it – such as Mughniyah – endowed Hizbollah with a violent, revolutionary profile, which it has been laboring to shake off in recent years.⁵

All of Lebanon has undergone major changes since the end of the civil war that ravaged the country (1975-1989).⁶ Thus, Hizbollah was not the only party seriously concerned over the review of the “old file.” Political sources in Beirut were taken aback at the United States decision to open “ancient notebooks in order to settle old accounts” with Lebanon.⁷ Prime Minister Rafiq al-Hariri, who quickly denied Mughniyah’s presence in the country, emphatically stated that Lebanon would not be held responsible for attacks and kidnappings that went on during the civil war: “First of all, for a long period Lebanon itself was a kidnapped state, a state that had no control over its own affairs – it is impossible to demand accountability from it.”⁸ In late January 2002, even Sheikh Subhi Tufayli, who served as Hizbollah’s first secretary-general and subsequently broke from its ranks yet is still considered the leader of Hizbollah’s radical-dogmatic line, hastened to deny any connection with the manifesto circulating then in the Lebanon Valley criticizing the organization’s line of activity and calling on unity in the ranks around “the brother, the jihad warrior, the hero, Haj Imad Mughniyah.” Publicly, Mughniyah was a liability, and while he remained active behind the scenes, the speed with which various elements in Lebanon repudiated his “services,” even if only for appearance’s sake,⁹ indicates the embarrassment felt in Hizbollah and Lebanon about confronting the stigma of its violent past.

A critical juncture in the history of Hizbollah as well as a turning point for Lebanon as a whole came in October 1989 with the signing of the Ta’if agreement that ended the Lebanese Civil War. As an agreement of national reconciliation, its central feature was the dissolution of all militias operating in the country; at the same time, it also contained a program of military reconstruction. In the end Hizbollah was not disarmed, but it was agreed that the organization’s fighters would move south and redeploy on the border with Israel. However, at this stage Hizbollah was still occupied in another arena of struggle, namely, against its main Shiite rival, the Amal movement. Close to the end of the civil war, Amal and Hizbollah were headed on a collision course, with violent clashes that included fatalities erupting in Beirut and Iqlim al-Tufah. Increased involvement by Iran and Syria eventually resulted in a ceasefire

imposed on the two competing organizations. The agreement was reached in late October 1990, was signed in Damascus on November 5, 1990, and took effect five days later. It determined that the two organizations would assist the Lebanese army in its deployment in the south of the country “according to the development of its ability to maintain law and order.” Section Two of the agreement stated that in the event of disputes between the two organizations, “both sides must submit to the interpretation proposed by the Syrian and Iranian representatives.”¹⁰

Thus, less than two years after Hizbollah’s secretary-general Tufayli had declared in January 1989 that his people would defend themselves against Amal “to the last drop of blood,” the organization turned the brunt of its focus to the struggle against the IDF and South Lebanese Army (SLA) stationed in the security zone since 1985. Furthermore, with the disbanding of the other militias, Hizbollah began to enjoy almost complete exclusivity in raising the banner of “resistance” against Israel. Significantly, though, even today the Lebanese and Arab press includes an article every few weeks about scuffles, brawls, and sometimes even bloodier clashes between Amal and Hizbollah supporters. This is an ongoing reminder that Hizbollah will perforce have to engage in a persistent political struggle for the Shiite voter.

In recent years, the majority of researchers and commentators studying Hizbollah’s trend to join the “establishment” regard it as the organization’s “Lebanonization.” This term implies that the organization was not originally a Lebanese creation, rather a foreign one, perhaps Iranian. Nasrallah and other senior Hizbollah officials, however, go out of their way to stress that their organization’s founding was inherently “a Lebanese response.” Nasrallah totally rejects the term “Lebanonization,” common among scholars, and prefers the word “opening-up” (*infatih*) to describe the organizational trend.

A symbolic but prominent milestone in this process of opening up – and one that gained much attention in Lebanon and the international community – was Hizbollah’s secretary-general’s acceptance on October 18, 2002 of the invitation to the opening ceremony of the Beirut summit of French-speaking states. This was the first time that Nasrallah attended an important international event that was not a political meeting or a symposium devoted to the conflict with Israel. One of the reasons that Lebanese president Emile Lahud was so insistent on inviting Nasrallah to the international convention was his desire to demonstrate Lebanon’s official view that Hizbollah is not a terrorist group, but a legitimate national organization with a political and social agenda.¹¹ The Lebanese media spotlighted Nasrallah’s extraordinary meeting and handshake with the leader of the Christian Maronite community in Lebanon, Patriarch Nasrallah Butrus Sfeir,¹² particularly notable since Sfeir was the most prominent public

figure to demand the ouster of the Syrian forces from Lebanon and deployment of the Lebanese army in the south.

Nasrallah's presence at the opening session of the summit reawakened the debate in Lebanon over Hizbollah's orientation and evolution. At the end of October 2002, word surfaced in Lebanon that the Hizbollah leadership was working on the final touches of the organization's new political platform, its first since February 1985. Deputy Secretary-General Na'im Qasim explained that "many things have happened . . . [between] 1985 and today. Our basic principles remain the same since they are the heart of our movement, but several other positions have changed because of the circumstances developing around us." Qasim stated that the new platform would reflect Hizbollah's moderate attitude toward the Lebanese Forces Party in Lebanon, toward the West in general, and toward France in particular. "France's position toward us has changed, so we must change ours," Qasim emphasized. Regarding Israel, he noted that, "Since many positions have changed, we must be flexible to change ours too. However, opposition to Israel is the core of our faith, and this will never change."¹³

In her book *Hizb'ullah: Politics and Religion*,¹⁴ the Lebanese scholar Amal Saad-Ghorayeb wrote that the "opening-up" or "Lebanonization" of Hizbollah stemmed from its realization that its commitment to establishing an Islamic republic in Lebanon was "unrealistic." According to Saad-Ghorayeb, the first expression of Hizbollah's flexibility was its decision to take part in parliamentary elections in 1992, a decision reached only after intense, fiery, internal debate that lasted several months. The election results gave Hizbollah twelve out of 128 seats in parliament (eight Hizbollah representatives and four delegates who joined its parliamentary faction).

In the 1996 parliamentary elections the organization suffered a slight setback. As "The Faction of Loyalty to the Resistance" (*Kutlah al-Wafaa' lil Muqawamah*), it received ten seats (seven Hizbollah and three delegates who later joined it). In the elections held after Israel's withdrawal in the autumn of 2000, the Faction regained its parliamentary strength and won twelve mandates (nine from Hizbollah, and three from other parties). These representatives serve as Hizbollah's voice in parliament on a variety of issues, and some are also members of parliamentary committees.¹⁵ Other Hizbollah representatives sit on the directorates of government companies. In other words, the organization's revolutionary fervor and ideological devotion often clash with the process of establishing political legitimacy and compel Hizbollah to make ideological compromises so it can adapt to the new reality and survive in it. This does not, however, imply in any way that Hizbollah is going through an identity crisis. The organization sees itself as entirely Lebanese, and its leaders are careful to express themselves publicly on domestic socio-economic issues, such as support for

the working class and the struggle against corruption and unemployment.

On a more symbolic level of the “Lebanonization” process, Hizbollah made a minor though significant change to the organizational flag, the yellow background on which are emblazoned the organization’s name, a rifle, the Quran, an outline of the globe, and above the rifle the slogan, taken from the Quran, “Hizbollah are the victors.” At a certain stage, however, the writing at the bottom of the flag was changed from “the Islamic Revolution in Lebanon” – a slogan reflecting Hizbollah’s early platform – to “the Islamic Resistance in Lebanon.” When questioned about this, Nasrallah replied, “We told our brothers to use both expressions, but the second one [the Islamic Resistance in Lebanon – *al-Muqawamah al-Islamiyah fi Lubnan*] was the one adopted. I believe that the second expression is more precise since Hizbollah began its path as a resistance [movement], continued on this path, and has remained as such. It best expresses Hizbollah and the nature of its activity.”¹⁶

The change was not merely in the wording on the bottom of the flag; it also implied an increasingly apparent metamorphosis in the organization at the declaratory level and in the practical sphere. Participation in national elections was one aspect of the transformation. Others included Nasrallah’s statements that the organization has no goal of establishing an Islamic republic in Lebanon, recognizes the diverse historical and religious backgrounds of the Lebanese people, and is aware of the majority’s antagonism toward an Islamic republic.¹⁷ Another indication of Hizbollah’s attempt to market itself to a wider Lebanese public can be observed in Nasrallah’s announcement of late 1997 regarding the establishment of the “Lebanese Resistance Battalions,”¹⁸ an initiative designed to integrate fighters from as wide-ranging an ethnic background as possible. In reality the battalions’ inclusion in the armed struggle against Israel was almost negligible, but its importance lies in the fact that Hizbollah initiated it. During the same period the groundwork was also prepared for one of the defining events in Hizbollah history: the violent confrontation in late 1998 between the movement’s mainstream and the faction headed by the former secretary-general, Tufayli. Tufayli was finally ousted from Hizbollah and became a persecuted figure whose activities have been banned by the authorities.

In the months prior to the clash, Tufayli had increasingly criticized both Hizbollah and the Lebanese government for the country’s deplorable economic situation. For a long time he threatened to incite a civil revolt that he termed “the Hunger Revolution.” At one point he advised residents in the Baalbek region to stop paying state taxes, claiming that he and his supporters would be forced “to raise the level of civil insurrection . . . [because of] government steps that include tax collection, the continuous acquisition of loans, the establishment of entertainment facilities and dance

halls, [as well as] robbing the treasury and starving the destitute.”¹⁹ This type of rhetoric is no longer heard from Hizbollah, which now invites government representatives to its public events and is intent on presenting itself as an integral part of the system.

Nasrallah and Hizbollah failed to divert Tufayli from his agenda, which included threats to block government ministers from entering Baalbek and “trashing the rulers’ palaces and throwing the debris into the sea.”²⁰ In a meeting with Hizbollah leaders, Tufayli was warned that Hizbollah “would not return to the state of isolation since the party is now more open [more involved in the political system] with all other parties and its political platform is clear to everyone.”²¹ In the face of Tufayli’s relentless criticism, however, Hizbollah eventually announced his banishment from its ranks.

Tufayli quickly convened a press conference (January 25, 1998) in his hometown of Brital in the Lebanon Valley, where he accused Hizbollah of instigating moves that were tantamount to “a split from Islam.” Speaking on Hizbollah’s decision to take part in the 1992 parliamentary elections, Tufayli stated: “It hurt me greatly that there were those who turned away from Islam.” On the same occasion he derided Hizbollah’s acquiescing to President Elias al-Harawi’s remaining in office, charging that it violated the Quran and that Hizbollah “has become one of the central pillars in the corrupt Lebanese system.” Finally, Tufayli tried persuading Iran to intervene “in order to set things right.”²²

Iran, however, did not rally to Tufayli’s cause to amend Hizbollah’s ways; instead, it moved against the former secretary-general. The explosion between the quarreling sides occurred on January 30, 1998, when the Lebanese army arrived in force and with the political backing of Syria and Iran.²³ Lebanese army units discovered in Tufayli’s headquarters large amounts of weapons, shells, explosives, and ammunition. The army’s public relations department made certain to post photographs of Tufayli’s destroyed radio station in the town of Duras. Since then, although he still retains a community of supporters, Tufayli’s voice has been heard only on rare occasions. In April 2001, for example, two rallies were held in Baalbek as the Ashuraa’ events approached – one was sponsored by Hizbollah and the other by Tufayli faithful. At the end of December 2001, Tufayli was sighted in the company of his followers as Jerusalem Day neared. In response, the Lebanese authorities announced that Tufayli was watched by national security agents and would be apprehended and brought to trial as soon as possible. In October 2002 another report surfaced that Tufayli and his supporters had decided to change the movement’s name from “the Hunger Revolution” to “Sheikh Subhi Tufayli’s Supporters,” a sign that the breakaway group was trying to soften its image. Nonetheless, in a series of interviews and public appearances in September 2003, Tufayli resumed his attack on Hizbollah and called

for renewed military activity against Israel: "Where is the resistance? [Former SLA commander Antoine] Lahd is gone, and they [Hizbollah] took his place and became a border patrol. Every few months [they shoot] one bullet."²⁴ Accusing Hizbollah of recognizing the "Zionist entity" and restraining anti-Israel activity, Tufayli declared, "I call on my Hizbollah brothers to rise in rebellion, and to refuse orders that call on them to serve as merely a border guard."²⁵

This parting of ways, which included Tufayli's final ouster from the organization that he had headed, offers an opportunity to examine the long road that Hizbollah has traveled from the time of its founding and its more recent decision to choose pragmatic integration into the Lebanese system over pure ideology. Today it no longer rejects the Lebanese government's legitimacy nor even considers replacing it with an alternative regime. On the contrary, Hizbollah is careful to show its respect of the will of the majority in the country. As for ties between Hizbollah and Tufayli since his ouster, according to Nasrallah, they have occurred in recent years only when necessary, and only through a third party acting as intermediary.²⁶ Nasrallah also refused to respond publicly to Tufayli's derision that Hizbollah had become a border guard, yet his associates were quoted as saying that igniting the southern border "does not serve the interests of Lebanon, Palestine, or the resistance."²⁷

Against this background, how is the organization's current ideology defined? Its first political, ideological platform was published on February 16, 1985 as a forty-eight page "proclamation" that was delivered in Beirut under the title "The Open Letter Addressed by Hizbollah to the Downtrodden in Lebanon and the World." The document states that one of Hizbollah's goals is to establish an Islamic republic in Lebanon, yet emphasizing that "despite Hizbollah's obligation to Islam, it would not force it on Lebanon."²⁸ The wording of the platform, whose cover bears the portrait of Iran's Islamic revolutionary leader, Ayatollah Ruhallah Khomeini, underscores the organization's Islamic dimension and its link to Iran. "We, the sons of Hizbollah's nation, whose vanguard God has given victory in Iran and which has established the nucleus of the world's central Islamic state, abide by the orders of a single wise and just command currently embodied in the supreme Ayatollah Ruhallah al-Musavi Khomeini." One of the main sections in the platform discusses the need to expel the Israelis, Americans, and French from Lebanese soil. The liberation of Jerusalem and annihilation of the State of Israel are also included among Hizbollah objectives.

Today Hizbollah views the original platform as outdated. True, the organization occasionally presents Secretary-General Nasrallah as the Lebanese representative of Iran's spiritual leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamene'i.²⁹ At the same time, it has been clearly observed in recent years that under Nasrallah's leadership, the organization has

invested much effort in casting for itself an unequivocally Lebanese image, discarding any suggestion that the organization caters to “foreign interests” – that is, to dictates emanating from Tehran or Damascus. Thus, Hizbollah is not solely an original Iranian “product,” but is also the foremost representative of Lebanon’s Shiite community, with connections dating back hundreds of years to Shiites in Iran and Iraq.

In one of his many interviews, Nasrallah was quick to point out with pride that in April 2002 the organization had kept up its military activity on Mt. Dov – its most serious escalation since Israel’s withdrawal – “even” after Iranian Foreign Minister Kamal Kharazi announced in Beirut that Hizbollah should act with restraint.³⁰ In previous years too, for example in May 1998, Nasrallah rebuffed the Iranian minister who had implied that following the Israeli pullback Hizbollah’s role would be concluded, stressing that the senior Iranian’s statements reflected the opinion of his country, not that of Hizbollah.

Hizbollah obscured its intentions by refusing to declare its objective once Israel would terminate its occupation of South Lebanon. After the withdrawal, it continued to dissemble how it would react should Israel end its presence at Shab’a Farms. It only hinted that additional demands might be made in the future. As for its vision, Hizbollah continues to adhere to its original position of the State of Israel as an illegitimate, “cancerous entity” that must be expunged from the map and returned to its “legal” owners – that is, to the Palestinian people. Muhammad Fnaysh, for example, a Hizbollah representative in parliament, declared on July 13, 2001 that “our struggle with the Zionist enemy is not a border conflict between two countries, but a confrontation with an entity whose aim is [the destruction of] our survival and future.”³¹ This is Hizbollah’s official position.

Behind such maximalist rhetoric, does Hizbollah truly believe the liquidation of Israel is an attainable goal? When asked about this, Secretary-General Nasrallah replied that if the Palestinians continued their present struggle, “neither Sharon nor one thousand generals like Sharon will be able to preserve this entity’s existence. I am counted among those who believe that the liberation of Palestine requires neither nuclear weapons nor a strategic balance.” To judge by the organization’s rhetoric, therefore, Hizbollah believes the destruction of Israel is a realizable goal. True, in the second part of his statement Nasrallah modified his words slightly, “You can tell me this is a dream. But I say that although there may be something of a dream here, there is also something of reality.”³² Thus, since anti-Zionist ideology forms an integral part of Hizbollah dogma, it is doubtful whether the organization would surrender its vision of “Greater Palestine,” even if regional peace is attained and precludes fulfillment of the vision.